School Leader Pathways, Selection, and Hiring

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K-12 Education
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Introduction

The vast body of research demonstrating the importance of school leadership for student, teacher, and school outcomes[1] indicates that recruiting and hiring high-quality leaders is a key goal for school districts. Building a bench of effective leaders ready to be hired into school leadership roles is an especially important policy objective given high annual rates of exit from the principal role.[2]

The goal of this chapter is to review the evidence on pathways of aspiring leaders into school leadership and on school leader selection and hiring. We focus specifically on pathways into the school principalship, although we also discuss pathways into the assistant principal (AP) role where relevant. Our review touches briefly on school leader preparation, but we leave in-depth discussion of the evidence on leader preparation to another chapter. Instead, we adopt a local perspective on school leader pathways and selection, considering how future leaders move across job experiences into leadership roles, how districts can structure experiences to help prepare educators for leadership, and what research suggests about effective district selection practices. Given the documented disparities in how women and educators of color access school leadership positions, we also review the evidence on where these disparities arise along the pathway into leadership and the degree to which selection and hiring practices may contribute.

Key Findings

Key finding #1: *States create formal requirements for school leader pathways through licensure requirements, but those requirements are not all supported by empirical evidence.*

Most states require 3–5 years of teaching experience, an advanced degree from an accredited program, and passage of a licensure assessment. Evidence supports a minimal but not a lengthy teaching requirement. However, evidence also suggests that licensure assessments may not predict success and can constrain the pool of leaders of color.

Key finding #2: *The typical pathway into a principal role includes obtaining a master's degree from a university-based preparation program, followed by work as an assistant principal, although there is usually a gap of multiple years between degree completion and taking any formal leadership role.*

Given state licensure requirements, it is unsurprising that most administrators enter leadership through a master's-level program. On average, their first administrative role comes approximately three years later and is typically an AP role. Most principals have at least three years of experience as an AP. Time as an AP increasingly characterizes the pathway to the principal's office, as the number of AP roles has expanded considerably in recent decades, making the AP job an important training ground for future principals.

Key finding #3: *As most school leaders are "homegrown," school districts are increasingly building their own "pipeline" programs to formalize leadership pathways at the local level, with some initial evidence of positive effects.*

School leadership labor markets are very local, so most principals are hired from within the school district. The tendency to hire locally creates opportunities for districts to invest in local preservice training opportunities and, increasingly, in larger "pipeline" initiatives that offer better coordination across preservice training, selection, and early-career support. Evidence suggests that pipeline programs can increase student achievement and improve principal selection.

Key finding #4: *Systematic research on principal hiring and selection is scarce and limited mostly to emerging evidence on characteristics of leaders who are likely to seek and be chosen for principal roles.*

Substantial additional research is needed on principal hiring processes, which are currently poorly understood. Hiring studies focus more on characteristics of principals who are hired, and these studies usually cannot differentiate whether these characteristics result from the characteristics of the labor pool (i.e., who applies) or decisions made by districts regarding who to hire. Beyond degree and experience as an administrator, more effective teachers and APs appear to be more likely to be hired—a positive finding because studies suggest that success in these prior roles predicts success in the principal's office. Intangible factors such as motivation to make a difference or to work with specific student populations also appear to predict being selected for the role.

Key finding #5: *Informal processes based on educator relationships are an important component of pathways into school leadership.*

"Tapping" or informal encouragement to pursue leadership in general or specific leadership positions appears to be a primary mechanism for identifying future school leaders. Reliance on informal mechanisms makes leader identification non-systematic and subject to in-group bias.

Key finding #6: *Scholars have found race/ethnicity and gender gaps along the principal pipeline, although in general gaps by race/ethnicity are small, and it appears that the gender gap in access to the principalship has narrowed substantially in recent years.*
Educators of color are represented in the principalship at roughly the same rate as in teaching. Nevertheless, research has documented disadvantages for people of color along the pathway into the school principalship, including lower rates of licensure examination passage and longer waits in AP roles before being hired into the principal's office. Women are substantially underrepresented, although the proportion of women in school leadership has grown markedly in recent decades. Historically, women appeared to aspire to become principals at lower rates. In recent years, differences in aspirations are less

apparent. Instead, differences in applying or being selected for principal roles may be greater contributors to the lower proportion of women in the principalship.

Evidence

Key finding #1: *States create formal requirements for school leader pathways through licensure requirements, but those requirements are not all supported by empirical evidence.*

State requirements for administrative licensure create formal structures for pathways into school leadership roles. States' licensure requirements are not uniform but have some similar elements.[3] First, most states require aspiring school leaders to have teaching experience (on average 3–5 years of teaching) or equivalent school-based experience (e.g., experience as a school counselor). Second, most states require prospective leaders to have an advanced degree in educational administration or a similar field from an accredited university preparation program, although many states also have provisions for obtaining licensure through an alternative route. Third, approximately 35 states require candidates to pass a standardized leadership licensure assessment that is aligned with state-adopted leadership standards.

Several studies have investigated the relationship between these licensure requirements and principal effectiveness. Some research suggests that principals who were teachers in the past are more effective at improving test score outcomes[4] and that more effective teachers may make more effective principals,[5] although time in the teaching role does not predict greater effectiveness.[6] These results support minimum teaching experience requirements—perhaps just enough years to reveal whether a teacher is instructionally effective—but argue against lengthier expectations. In short, the typical requirement of 3–5 years appears reasonable.

Evidence for licensure requirements is less positive. We leave review of the evidence on preservice preparation to another chapter. However, note that a simple requirement of completing an approved preparation program is unlikely to meet state goals of ensuring some baseline of leadership effectiveness given the documented wide variation in preparation programs and their graduates' outcomes, even within a given state.[7] Evidence on the role of licensure assessments also raises concerns about requiring them. A study of the most commonly required assessment, the School Leaders Licensure Assessment, using Tennessee data showed not only that scores failed to predict principals' future effectiveness but that minimum score requirements kept potential leaders of color—who scored systematically lower—out of the school leader labor pool.[8] Alternatives to standardized assessments, such as portfolio-based performance assessments, offer potential to better measure leader candidates' capacities and have shown minimal score gaps across candidates from different racial and ethnic groups.[9]

Key finding #2: *The typical pathway into school leadership includes obtaining a master's degree from a university-based preparation program, followed by work as an assistant principal, although there is usually a gap of multiple years between degree completion and taking any formal leadership role.*

Unsurprisingly given the preceding discussion of licensure requirements, research shows that obtaining a master's degree is the most common initial step along the pathway into school leadership.[10] The master's degree is the highest degree obtained for about 60% of school principals, with the other 40% going on to obtain education specialist or doctoral degrees.[11]

Typically, the move from degree program to a leadership role is not immediate. On average, it takes graduates 5–6 years from completion of their program to obtain a principal position, although it generally takes only half that time to move into an AP role.[12]

Indeed, serving as an AP is increasingly a step along the pathway to becoming a principal. The fraction of public school principals with AP experience rose from 50% to 77% between 1988 and 2016,[13] paralleling pronounced growth nationwide in the number of AP roles in schools.[14] Studies find that AP is the most common prior position for leaders hired as principals.[15] High leadership ratings in the AP role are a strong predictor of high ratings as an early-career principal, and serving as an AP in a high-growth school or under a successful principal also appears to increase future principal effectiveness, highlighting the AP role as an important training ground for future principals.[16] Still, pathways through other roles remain common in many areas; in Oregon, for example, non-trivial numbers of principals are hired from teaching, school support, and central office positions, among other roles.[17]

Key finding #3: *As most school leaders are "homegrown," school districts are increasingly building their own "pipeline" programs to formalize leadership pathways at the local level, with some initial evidence of positive effects.*

Most school leaders are "homegrown"—that is, districts hire leaders from within the ranks of current employees at very high rates.[18] A tendency to select leaders from a highly localized labor pool creates opportunities for school districts to offer localized training and development opportunities for future leaders in the district. Some of these opportunities are partnerships with universities or other partners that help candidates meet state licensure requirements, while others are supplemental, taking the form of additional local training for already-licensed leaders. The former group includes residency training models, such as those implemented in New York City and Chicago, that make a year-long apprenticeship under a current principal in a local school a main component of preparation.[19] The latter group includes local aspiring principal academies or other training aimed at aspiring leaders facilitated by the district or a partner.[20]

Increasingly, school districts are building out their investment in training for local future leaders into more comprehensive "pipeline" programs that formalize pathways into school leadership in the district. Pipeline programs increase coordination of human capital activities related to school leaders by connecting local preservice training to selective hiring and support once the leader transitions into the job. For example, six urban districts supported by the Wallace Foundation's Principal Pipeline Initiative redesigned their systems to articulate standards that drove preservice preparation and hiring criteria, offered new training for high-potential APs, and made principal hiring more data-driven, among other changes.[21] The results were promising; principals coming through district pipelines saw substantially higher achievement in their schools and were less likely to turn over.[22]

Key finding #4: *Systematic research on principal hiring and selection is scarce and limited mostly to emerging evidence on characteristics of leaders who are likely to seek and be chosen for principal roles.*

Research on principal selection is limited. As a recent review article noted, almost no systematic scholarly attention has been paid to the processes school districts use to hire school principals.[23] Instead, research in this area tends to focus on the characteristics of principals who are hired. This research has identified some useful patterns. However, because studies typically do not have access to finer-grained data from principal selection processes, they are unable to differentiate the degree to which patterns arise from

differences in who applies for principal jobs versus which applicants are chosen from the available pool. One study using Illinois data comes closest to this differentiation, employing surveys of a sample of administrative certificate earners to separate application and job offer information (though failing to differentiate principal roles from AP or other administrative roles).[24] Still, gaining a better understanding of principal hiring and selection dynamics and the outcomes they produce is a major need for the field.

Newly hired principals typically have prior administrative experience (e.g., as an AP) and often hold advanced degrees. In a study of Tennessee data, the typical new principal had been an AP for three years, and 43% had obtained an education specialist or doctorate degree.[25] Illinois applicants with prior administrative experience and advanced degrees were more likely to receive job offers. Conditional on experience and degree, districts also appear to prefer younger applicants.[26]

Studies also find that educators chosen to be principals were more effective when they were teachers and when they were APs;[27] as already mentioned, these characteristics also appear to predict early-career principal effectiveness. However, newly hired principals selected to lead lower-achieving, higher-poverty schools tend to have lower qualifications and to have been less effective in the AP role.[28]

Research also documents some intangible factors that appear relevant to leader selection. In Illinois, licensed individuals who reported higher motivation to make a difference were more likely to seek administrative roles, though interestingly, they were less likely to be offered those roles.[29] In interviews in two urban systems, researchers similarly found motivations to work with specific student populations (e.g., students of color, English learners) to be a key determinant of where principal applicants sought leadership positions.[30]

Key finding #5: *Informal processes based on educator relationships are an important component of pathways into school leadership.*

Informal processes grounded in educator relationships also appear to be important for principal selection and to school leadership pathways more generally. Informal "tapping" is consistently identified as a primary mechanism for identifying prospective school leaders.[31] Studies find that aspiring principals are often tapped or encouraged to apply for specific principal vacancies.[32] They also find that teachers who have been tapped for leadership by their supervisors are more likely to apply for principal positions and successfully secure them than teachers who were not tapped.[33] The challenges of relying on tapping for leader identification are its non-systematic nature and its potential for in-group bias regarding who advances along the leadership pathway.[34]

Key finding #6: *Scholars have found race/ethnicity and gender gaps along the principal pipeline, although in general gaps by race/ethnicity are small, and it appears that the gender gap in access to the principalship has narrowed substantially in recent years.*

Several studies have found differences in pathways into the principalship by leader race/ethnicity and gender. To put these studies in context, national estimates show that the race/ethnicity distribution of principals is similar to that of teachers. As of 2020–21, public school principals were approximately 77% white, 10% Black, and 9% Hispanic. That same year, public school teachers were 80% white, 6% Black, and 9% Hispanic.[35] That is, relative to teaching, Black educators are somewhat overrepresented in school principal positions, which is important context for interpreting studies that tend to find disadvantages for Black educators on the principal pathway. At the same time, women are much less likely to be public school principals than teachers (56% vs. 77%), though, importantly, there has

been substantial progress for women gaining access to the principalship over the last 30 years.[36]

Studies of data from individual states find barriers for educators of color at different stages along the path to becoming a principal. Licensure is one such stage. Many states require passage of a standardized test such as the School Leaders Licensure Assessment for administrative licensure. A study of Tennessee leaders showed that Black educators were much less likely than their white colleagues to exceed the required cut score, potentially reducing the pool of prospective APs and principals of color.[37] Despite the constraints of licensure requirements, however, educators of color, especially Black educators, are more likely than white educators to be hired into AP roles, due in part to the higher prevalence of AP jobs in urban areas, which employ more educators of color.[38]

One study of Texas data found that, once in AP roles, Black and Hispanic leaders were less likely to be hired as principals or had to wait longer before being hired.[39] Another Texas study found that, overall, Black and Hispanic leaders obtaining administrative certification were less likely to become principals than their white colleagues.[40] A third highlighted that this lack of access to the principalship is especially true of female educators of color.[41] The field needs additional research from other states to examine these patterns, given representation patterns at the national level.

A study in Illinois suggests that these patterns occur despite evidence that people of color are more likely to apply for principal jobs. However, they are less likely to be offered them, and when offered, they are less likely to accept them, suggesting there are added barriers or possible disincentives to taking the positions that are available to them.[42]

Historically, the underrepresentation of women in the principalship relative to teaching began even before the licensure stage. National data from the late 1980s showed that female teachers were much less likely than men to hold a degree in administration, suggesting that women were less likely to aspire to school leadership.[43] By the 2000s, however, women appear to have caught up substantially. For example, in Tennessee, 70% of candidates taking the administrative licensure exam between 2004 and 2014 were women, approaching parity with their fraction in teaching in the state (79%). They were also much more likely to pass than their male colleagues.[44]

Underrepresentation of women may instead reflect differences in job-seeking and hiring. In Illinois, women reported applying to open principal positions less frequently and were less likely to be offered positions they applied for.[45] Texas data show that women have longer pathways into the principalship (i.e., they enter with more years of educational experience), although studies of Texas data reach different conclusions about whether women are more or less likely to be promoted once securing an AP role. Those data do show that women are less likely to be chosen to lead high schools and that promotion differences are intersectional, with female educators of color facing more challenges than white women.[46] One study documented that Black women hired into principal roles report encountering gendered racism throughout the process.[47]

Gender differences in access to leadership roles may result from differences in informal identification processes. Evidence suggests that educators who have been “tapped” (that is, encouraged to pursue leadership) by supervisors are more likely to apply to open principal positions, but women are less likely than men to report such tapping.[48]

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